

# ***The Social Radars***

## **S2: Adora Cheung, Co-Founder of Homejoy & Instalab**

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Jessica: I'm Jessica Livingston, and Carolynn Levy and I are the Social Radars. In this podcast, we talk to some of the most successful founders in Silicon Valley about how they did it. Carolynn and I have been working together to help thousands of startups at Y Combinator for almost 20 years. Come be a fly on the wall as we talk to founders and learn their true stories.

Carolynn, today we have such an exciting guest. I'm so happy to have her on today. It's Adora Cheung. Now we've known Adora for years. YC funded her in 2010 with a company called Pathjoy, and I'm going to ask her to talk about that. But it evolved into a company then called Homejoy. And then she became a YC partner for five years and now has a new company. So let's just get into things. Adora, welcome. We have so much to talk about with you. We got to start at the beginning, I guess.

Adora: Yes, sounds good.

Carolynn: Why not?

Jessica: Can you go back and tell the story about what Homejoy was and how it evolved?

Adora: Yeah, so we started 2009-ish before we applied to YC with a company called Pathjoy. Funny enough we came back in a loop and came back to the original idea almost, but it was a marketplace for services. And we were choosing which vertical to help, and we ended up on therapists and life coaches. And so that's how the name Pathjoy came about. It's like a path to joy, something like that. And that's what we applied to YC with.

And for a number of reasons, we got a lot of people on the supply side to put up their services, but we couldn't get the demand going. And so during YC we started pivoting and I would say for the next two years we were pivoting around for an idea that would work. And we ended up eventually on Homejoy, which was a marketplace for home service providers. And we were known mostly for cleaning. But yeah, I think we pivoted a dozen times. I can't even remember all the pivots at this point.

Jessica: That's important. You pivoted around a dozen times. That is a lot of pivoting. And there was something unique though about Homejoy, which was you were solving a problem that at least Aaron your brother and co-founder had. Can you tell the listeners about that?

Adora: Yeah, we were working on... I forgot what we were working on, the time.

Jessica: You were working on the... You were making a site for entertainment news.

Adora: Oh yeah, that's right. So to make money, the little money we could, because we didn't raise that much money leading up to this, we created... Back then there was this thing called Demand Media. There were a lot of people creating content machines where you create a bunch of websites, you'd SEO the terms and stuff like that. And one of the big places where you could acquire users really quickly was Google News.

I don't know if that exists anymore, but basically we put up, one of the things that people like to read about is entertainment news, and I think this was probably before TMZ and stuff like that. And so we put up a site for that and got a lot of users that way and made a little bit of money doing that. But yeah, we were really focused on scaling out this idea of a content machine and working on that.

But at the same time, Aaron, he's a pretty simple person, but he doesn't like to cook. He doesn't like to clean. I mean, he's some cool bachelor guy. And he was trying to find a good cleaner to basically help him with some of that stuff. And he just ran into this issue of just not being able to find someone good. And so he just presented the idea.

He was like, "This sounds like a problem, not just me, but probably a lot of other people have. Then let's go down that path and try to verify that idea." And so that's how that started. Our first customers were in Mountain View at that time, and so we put up a phone number on site. People started calling us, asking us what our service was. By this time we hadn't convinced a cleaner to work with us yet.

We learned from the first time, get the demand, like see if there's demand first. And there's probably plenty of supply. I forget who our first customer was, how they found us, but we did a lot of posting posters down Mountain View. It was during the hot summer months when we started, and so to get people to talk to us about our company, there was a festival on that street on Castro Street, and we lugged out bottles of water, iced water, and gave them out and tried to get people to sign up.

And eventually someone signed up and it turned out to be this huge house in Los Altos, Hills or somewhere. And we hadn't found a cleaner yet. And so of course we were... Actually, I was a cleaner. So I showed up. I forgot who I brought with me, but I showed up. It was this huge house. Had never cleaned a house in my life. I mean, obviously I cleaned my own apartment, but to clean an entire home this big, and it was under construction, which is like another whole mess because there was dust everywhere. And the dust would keep coming back once you started cleaning.

And it took me forever to clean that house. Just took me over 12 hours, and I don't even think I really did that good of a job. And so once we started getting more customers, we were able to start building up the supply side of the equation and get other people who knew how to clean efficiently. It's actually pretty simple to clean, but it's the efficiency of doing it, that's the hard part. And doing it in an order and sequence that gets it done in a timely manner.

Jessica: But you took this to an extreme by, you cleaned more than just that one place. I mean, did you use to go up to San Francisco and sleep in your car?

Adora: So in that period of figuring out, I didn't know how to clean, Aaron's first thought was, let's go get books to learn how to clean. And so we had these cleaning books.

Jessica: I love that.

Adora: That obviously is not the way to learn how to clean efficiently. And so I was like, "Okay, I just got to learn by doing." And so I got a job as a cleaner for this cleaning company in San Francisco. And so there you start in the morning. So I was living in Mountain View. By the way, part of the story is I applied to many cleaning jobs, trying to get a job to learn how to clean. And they all mostly rejected me except for this one company in San Francisco.

Jessica: Why? Wait what?

Adora: And so that's why I ended up in San Francisco, not just in Mountain View doing that job.

Jessica: Yeah, why did they reject you?

Carolynn: Why did they reject you?

Adora: I don't have any experience clearly. And it was just sort of this, why are you coming to us wanting this? Why don't you go get an engineering job, go get some other job. What is it? I think there was just like-

Jessica: You had a PhD or graduate degree in computer science, right?

Adora: I spent four years in a PhD program for economics.

Jessica: Oh, okay.

Adora: I mean, there's a lot of people searching for these jobs, and so you got to be really good at this to really get that particular job. So anyway, I got this job in San Francisco, and had this great partner. She actually taught me how to clean, I think she didn't know what to do with me in the beginning, but you got to... The first job is at seven o'clock, 6:30, seven o'clock.

I lived in Mountain View at that time. And so to get to the job on time, you're either in traffic a lot going up the highway or you have to just get there really early like four o'clock in the morning and just sleep there in the car for a little bit, take a nap and then go to the job. Then I could come back down around three o'clock maybe to get back to work on the company.

Jessica: Sleep in the car in San Francisco?

Adora: Yeah, it's probably not there anymore, but there was around fourth and... There was a McDonald's somewhere there in Soma, and I think that's where-

Jessica: You brush your teeth in the McDonald's bathroom or something. Right? I remember some little nuggets like that.

Adora: Yeah. Yeah. I was a little crazy back then, but I was just-

Jessica: You weren't scared at all sleeping in your car?

Adora: No, I think San Francisco was fine at that time.

Jessica: Okay, so you get this hands-on experience. I have to ask this really tangential question. What did you learn about how to clean? How do you clean efficiently?

Adora: It's the right tools first and foremost. So the right cloths to use, the mop, vacuums, everything and the right liquids, essentially chemicals. And so some of these companies really have it figured out. They have four bottles and you do this for that glass. This is from the microwave, this is for the oven, stuff like that.

And then after that it's a sequence, and what you do is, you want to go from top to bottom in to out. And then it's also the way you split the work. So if you go with a partner, if you can split the work in a certain way, you can get things done much quicker. So it's not rocket science, but it's just sort of things you wouldn't think of until you actually need to do it within. And you got to get in and out within an hour or two hours, essentially. So this is a time gig.

Carolynn: Let me just ask though, while you're actually literally cleaning homes and learning how to do it. Meanwhile, Aaron or you or somebody, you're trying to hire cleaners and stuff, so you know there's an end. You know you're not going to be doing this for very long. Okay?

Adora: Yes. Yeah, I think it was, I wanted to make sure the jobs I was doing for our own company were going well and also it allowed me to figure out how to onboard cleaners on our end much better and what are the right questions to ask and stuff like that.

Carolynn: For how long was this particular period of time that you did?

Adora: I did it for about a month.

Carolynn: Okay.

Adora: I think that company still owes me my last paycheck, but it was because I had forgotten. I lost the shirt they gave me. And so you were supposed to return back all the stuff.

Carolynn: No, that's actually not legal. You have to get your last paycheck. Even if you can't put conditions on payroll, you can't. They do owe you that shirt or no shirt.

Jessica: Maybe the shirt was lost in Aaron's messy apartment.

Carolynn: Maybe the paycheck was lost in Aaron's apartment. Wait, wait. So just to point out the irony, the two people running the cleaning startup had the messiest apartment. Is that what the message is?

Adora: Oh yes.

Carolynn: That's funny.

Adora: Oh yes.

Jessica: You're creating this marketplace because it's basically on-demand cleaners. And so you are now getting to be experts on both sides. How did you then get things kicked off with the marketplace and acquiring users. And wasn't it like a landrush business at that point? Because this is in 2012.

Adora: It wasn't for like a good six, nine months, I think we were by ourselves in terms of a tech business trying to corner this market. It was just little by little. Like on the cleaner side we posted on Craigslist and just met with people and really tried to convince them that we do have customers and that they're going to get paid on time and all these things. The cleaning business is not the best business in the world, and so a lot of people get screwed over. And so we were just trying to make sure that we are going to pay you on time and we're legitimate.

And on the demand side, it was just we put up a website. I think the biggest thing we actually did was put a phone number on there and we get calls at all random times, but I think when you're not a well-known company, just having a way for you to contact them and hear you on the phone was I think important.

And so we were able to get a few people in the door that way on top of just handing out flyers and stuff like that around Mountain View. We got a few people and then people just started talking about us and it rolled from there. Before we raised a proper seed round, we didn't do any advertising because we just didn't have the money to do it, but it was just referral based in the very beginning.

Jessica: But you guys then became experts in user acquisition or Aaron always already was an expert?

Adora: Yeah, Aaron is the genius in this.

Jessica: Okay.

Adora: He's very good at conversion funnel stuff. I mean, I do this a lot with product funnels and stuff like that, but he's very good at just looking at the numbers and running the ads and trying to get your customer acquisition costs down and stuff like that.

Jessica: Did you know you always wanted to start something with him?

Adora: No. No, not at all. He actually, I think, got into startups a little bit during school. He went to MIT, which is a hub of just entrepreneurs, about soon to be entrepreneurs. And so he got into it probably his first year, freshman year of college. I didn't even know about startups or tech stuff really until grad school when a friend just came by and was like, I need help with this startup I'm doing. He needed a programmer. And so I just started helping him with that.

Jessica: You knew how to program, you just didn't know about startups?

Adora: Yes. Yes, I was a compsci major in undergrad. And then, yeah, I didn't want any of the jobs that I could get at that point, so that's why I went to grad school for economics. But I hadn't done any web programming, for example. All the stuff I was taught was more desktop applications, cc plus plus, stuff like that. And so it just never occurred to me that Silicon Valley actually existed. By the way, I'm from South Carolina, so that's my world-

Jessica: Clemson, right?

Adora: ... at that time.

Jessica: Okay.

Adora: Clemson. Yes.

Jessica: And I remember you telling me once that your mom was not that psyched about you guys doing a startup.

Adora: Oh yeah. I mean your kid goes to MIT and then all of a sudden he's working on something that she doesn't know where it's going. And I mean, we're an immigrant family and so the next step is get a good job, go work in McKinsey or Goldman Sachs or one of these places. And so yeah, she wasn't too happy. I don't even know if she still understands today what's going on.

Carolynn: So wait, the exact quote I remember from Adora is that her mom said, "What have you done with my star child?" Meaning Aaron?

Adora: Yes, he's the star child. She's like, "You couldn't choose on anyone else, but you chose him to get him into this mess."

Carolynn: But you chose my star child. It was enormous, all of that. Aaron wanted to do a startup.

Jessica: Because there are four of you, right? Four siblings?

Adora: There's four of us. And my current co-founder is my other brother, Alex.

Carolynn: I didn't know that.

Jessica: No way.

Adora: Yes. And I just learned, apparently I had said something to him at some point where he was convinced also to... Or actually Aaron graduated, but he dropped out of school to just focus on programming and getting software engineer jobs and stuff like that. And so I didn't even know that until recently. I was like, "Oh God, this is a double-landing for me at this point."

Jessica: And so he wasn't greasing the skids for your mother and her ability-

Carolynn: To cope.

Jessica: ... to comprehend the dropping... Yeah, her ability to cope.

Adora: No.

Carolynn: That's funny.

Jessica: Oh wow. We're going to talk about Instalab a little bit later. I still want to go back to Homejoy. Paul reminded me, I had forgotten this, but you were raising money, I forget which round, and no one was really that interested. And so he tweeted your revenue growth chart anonymously. He didn't say it was your company and suddenly got lots of interest.

Adora: Yes.

Jessica: Do you feel like that was just people weren't interested in the cleaning business or do you think it's because you were a woman?

Adora: I mean, honestly, obviously I don't know the actual answer to that. I don't think it was the cleaning business. I think everyone was into the on-demand model at that point. So if you could shove any sort of vertical in that, you could probably raise money if you're growing really fast. What are the other factors? It could be that I'm a female founder. It could be a number of things.

I mean, I remember at some point I actually asked Aaron to stop coming to meetings with me because it was like, "Hey, I'm the CEO over here asking me the questions. These are questions I can answer." And because I'm an engineer too, I didn't need Aaron in the room with me. I could just answer all the technical questions, all the product questions and business questions. And I think that helped me a bit, like them just focusing on me as being the leader of the company.

Jessica: Oh, interesting.

Carolynn: It's such a familiar story. Co-founder, male, female, the investors only talk to the male co-founder. We hear that a lot.

Adora: Yeah, it's a little bit frustrating, but yeah, I'm sure that was part of it, but who knows.

Jessica: Another question I usually don't ask about, but I'm going to ask you because I trust you to be honest about this. Why did your company fail?

Adora: I used to think when companies fail, there's probably this one thing that caused it to happen, but the more I look back on this, I just think there were a number of things, but maybe I can just highlight two or three of them because I don't have the time to go through all of it.

The number one thing that I think happened is that we rapidly scaled a broken product essentially. And so I think it's okay to scale a product that's not fully there. It's a little bit broken, stuff like that, but we were just pumping the growth on something that wasn't clearly working. And what do I mean by that? So the product itself was people essentially booking cleaning and the cleaning got done. And that worked really well when we were just in San Francisco and LA. Those were our first two markets.

But once we started getting more cleaners on the platform and more jobs getting done, that product, when you scale that product, you have to have different features and you have to have different operational techniques to get that all done in a smooth manner. And so instead of pausing or maybe just slowing down growth a little bit, we were just essentially scaling up this thing that just kept getting worse and worse and worse.

And so you can see it in the numbers. I tell most people who are just building marketplaces, or any type of consumer type company, you can look at retention, you can look at your review ratings like one star to five star, you can look at NPS and all this kind of thing, but ultimately you just go back and look at retention.

And like I said, in the beginning, retention was great. And then I think it just started slowly going down. And then I think there's always this threshold that it's different for every company, but if your retention numbers get below a certain point, you should stop. You should stop and fix the thing and go.

But I think as a first time founder, it's just addicted to growth and you want to keep growing. You've got investors telling you, yeah, keep growing, keep growing, keep growing. You can fix it along the way, but it just gets complicated. Our company, I don't know, got to almost 300 people at some point, not including the contractors, the cleaners on the platform. And as you add more people to it, the communication overhead gets a lot harder and it's just hard to fix things.

And so even something small, putting in one new feature took weeks of rollout because it's not just... And we're in a lot of cities and so it's not just like, let's roll out to everyone in San Francisco. You got to have this whole plan to roll out to everywhere and then you can't iterate because that feature work or not that took about a month to figure out and it's just rolling back or just trying to improve on it was just very hard.

And so I think if we had done the thing where we're just like we're in three or four cities, really got the product, grew really fast in those cities, figured out how to get to some



level of growth with those good retention numbers, we would have been much better off going to the 30 other cities that we went to.

Carolynn: Oh wow. You went to 30 other cities.

Adora: Yeah. And so it was just too aggressive. We were in Europe at that time.

Carolynn: Oh my gosh. Wow.

Adora: Yeah, we were just everywhere very fast. And then there was also, we got into a price war. The whole cleaning thing became a bunch of companies started coming into the space and we got into a price war. We started offering \$19 cleanings. How can you make money on \$19 cleanings? Oh, the answer is you can't because you gotta pay the cleaners to do the job and they're not going to do that job for \$19.

I mean, the idea was get them in the door and then get them to book the next cleaning, but if your retention numbers aren't there, then that next cleaning sometimes doesn't come or a lot of times doesn't come. And so yeah, I think the companies we're competing against, we just all end up around the \$19 price for some reason. And I don't think that worked out for anyone, honestly.

Lesson learned there is you should know what your competitors are doing, that's smart, but you shouldn't be measuring yourself against them. Build your own high quality product. The prices don't have to come down. People will pay for high quality. And so that was the mistake there. Yeah, I would say those are the two main things that really, if we had maybe paused a little bit and turned the corner a little bit and stopped doing those things, would the company still be running? Maybe. I'm not sure. But it would've definitely helped a whole lot.

Carolynn: As this started to fall apart and you realized like, "Oh, maybe we're going to shut this down." Were you and Aaron totally in sync on that stuff?

Adora: Yes and no. I think we disagreed on some things, but I think there was a disagreement within the company on just taking, one's to write down just to stop this and take down growth and just fix it. And so I obviously didn't make that decision in time, whereas some people were ringing alarm bells a little bit earlier. At the end of the day, it is what it is, I suppose. But yeah, I think at the very end we were pretty aligned on here's the outcome and here's the lessons learned, and if we'd ever do anything again, here's what we would've done and do.

Jessica: So after Homejoy, you became a Y Combinator partner.

Adora: Yes.

Jessica: I want to talk about experiences you had on the other side. What did you learn from your five years of advising startups?

Adora: That's a good question. Well, it's definitely easier to give advice than to actually take it and do it. I think I learned a lot of what good founders are made of. I suppose just from seeing so many people come in the door and the qualities they all bring. When you interview founders and you're reading the applications and stuff like that, you get this understanding of are they good at communicating? Do they seem like they're going to run through walls? Do they have perseverance? Stuff like that.

I think the one thing I've learned is it's not just that there's a sub quality there from being able to run through walls, which is what's the best way to say it? One of my favorite shows is Ted Lasso and he has this quote, "Be a goldfish." And so it's that quality, which is like shit happens every day, good things and bad things happen every day. And I think the good founders, they will take the bad thing, they'll take the lesson learned immediately and they'll just move on and they'll just forget about whatever that thing is.

But if you're the type of person that dwells on that and you start becoming one of those over thinkers, thinking too much about bad things and then just not being able to move on and move past that and your decision-making abilities take longer and longer, and so you aren't able to move the startup forward. And so I think just when founders get stuck in there, it's just trying to identify that moment and try to unwind them a little bit and help them move on. And that is something I learned where I could be helpful in those moments I think.

Jessica: Because founders, it is good when they're decisive.

Adora: Oh yeah, you have to be. Things are moving too quickly for you to take days to make a decision.

Carolynn: Yeah, cycling is a bad sign. That's something you learned pretty fast.

Jessica: Do you remember any crazy stories from YC?

Adora: Oh, there is one. I think my favorite thing we do at YC beyond chatting with founders that were in the program was reading applications. And I love that. I think a lot of people didn't, but this is one of my favorite activities. And then Startup School. So I was part of Startup School for a while, and it wasn't my favorite moment in the moment, but looking back, it's just like this crazy thing that happened.

So we were at demo day. Right now Startup School is like everyone, you just sign up and you do it. Back then there was an application process because we were trying to put people in the group so that they could get mentored by other YC alum. And so you can't have an infinite number of startups doing Startup School.

Jessica: Let me interrupt you though, when you're talking about Startup School, it was online at this point?

Adora: Yes.

Jessica: Because Startup School comes up in almost every episode and it's usually the original in-person event. So I just wanted to point out that they morphed into an online version.

Carolynn: This is like 2017, 2018, I think, right? Around 2017, yeah.

Adora: Yeah.

Carolynn: I know the story and I remember it vividly.

Jessica: I remember it too, but not enough that I'm not excited to hear it.

Adora: And so we were in the middle of demo day and just I'm helping lots of founders out and we're about to put this announcement out of who got into Startup School, the mentoring part of this session, and then all of a sudden these emails go out. And what we realize is we told the people who didn't get in that they got in and then the opposite for the people who got in. And so we were just like, "Oh, no." And so our first reaction was just to apologize for it, like, "Oh." And then we just started realizing, oh no, okay, we've just screwed a bunch of people over.

Jessica: Like thousands. I remember it was thousands of people.

Adora: Yeah, Startup School is this huge monster. A lot of people are involved with it or signed up for it. And so it was the middle of demo day and just a lot of hectic things going on. And I think it was Jared who basically was like, "Hey, why don't we just let everyone in the door?" And I was like, "Oh." Because I'm the one running this thing, Jared's not running it. I got to deal with all this. I'm like, "Oh God, no. That's horrible. That's a horrible idea."

But I think at the end of the day when I thought through, like, "Okay, what is the mission of Startup School? What are we doing here? And that's to teach everyone in the world who wants to become an entrepreneur, how to go through that process." And so I was like, "Okay, we'll figure it out and let's just let everyone in."

And so that was the genesis of Startup School having basically no application process and you to just sign up and do it. And I think it was for the better. It was a little bit we had to restructure. At that point, I was working with Jeff on this, and we just had to restructure a lot of stuff, but we made it happen.

Jessica: Talk about turning lemons into lemonade.

Adora: There was a moment where I was super angry and I was like, "Oh God, you got to just QA this stuff. You're going to send out thousands of emails."

Jessica: I remember thinking, "Why the hell did they do this on demo day?"

Carolynn: Yeah, that's true.

Jessica: Just never double book yourself when it comes to demo day because demo day is like you're stretched.

Carolynn: You asked about anecdotes while she was your partner with you, but I was actually wondering if you have any anecdotes from your batch from summer '10?

Adora: Oh, so long ago. What do I remember? I met some of my best friends from that batch.

Jessica: Yuri Sagalov was in there, right?

Adora: Yeah. Yuri. It's like a circle of life, sort of YC. It's like you become friends with all these people and then you become investors in the company. I'm an LP in Yuri's fund who was probably the most underrated VC. He probably hates that word, but investor in Silicon Valley. But he's so good. Who else? There was Yuen, who started a company and invested his company. Adam Goldstein from Hipmunk.

Carolynn: Hipmunk. Yeah.

Adora: Yeah. He started a new company recently in biotech investor in that company.

Carolynn: Awesome. Oh wow.

Adora: So it was PagerDuty, Solomon who also became-

Jessica: Docker.

Carolynn: Docker. Yeah, PagerDuty, Docker.

Adora: PagerDuty, Docker. There's Hipmunk. And then I'm forgetting, oh, France is an ed from Tabzilla who started a new company called Flex, which is humongous right now.

Jessica: Oh wow.

Adora: Yeah, the memories are really not really from the batch, but from afterwards when we had time to just chill out a little bit and we try to recreate the weekly dinners by the people who hung out, stayed around Mountain View in Palo Alto, we would go out, try to go out once or every other week to get dinner or drinks down on California. There was Antonio's Nut House, which apparently doesn't exist anymore.

Jessica: Yes, it's gone. Antonio's Nut House. Not that I went there a lot, but I walked past there every day to my favorite breakfast joint.

Adora: I was trying to think of batch memories, maybe it was demo day. So back then you guys had all these investors and you tried to cram them into that one Mountain View office. And so you have to get so many investors in that batch. And so you have to do three sessions. Do you remember this?

Jessica: Yes. Oh, because it was in the Pioneer Way office.

Adora: Yes.

Jessica: And we just physically did not have the space, so we just had a whole slew of demo days.

Carolynn: Painful.

Adora: Yeah. And I did not do demo day really well. I remember the first time I did it, there were all these people and their heads were bopping like this, and I was just too focused on the head bopping. And then all of a sudden they're like, a woman just bopped her up really high over here and it's Demi Moore. And I'm just like, "What? What is she doing here?"

Jessica: Talked about her recently.

Adora: And I just really forgot what I was supposed to say. I don't know what I said during the first one. The second session was okay, and the third session it was hot. I think it was super hot that day and I was almost stroking out and I should have brought water with me.

Jessica: And we didn't have great AC or fan situations.

Adora: And I just remember I didn't pass it out, but I was like, "Oh God, I just need to focus and not pass out right now." But yeah, anyway, things are much better with these demo days. They're all online now, so there's no passing out.

Jessica: No, they're more organized and professionally run and more bathrooms to accommodate the guests-

Carolynn: Cool air and the like.

Jessica: ... and all that sort of stuff. So I want to jump to something that no one really knows about that happened around 2020 around the presidential election. You disappeared from the startup world to apply your knowledge behind the scenes to the Democratic Party without their knowledge. Am I describing it correctly?

Adora: Yes. After Trump got elected in 2016, I remember that day because we were just finishing interviews and we had just discovered this because we're not looking at everything during the day. And it was just sort of this disbelief and like, "Oh God, what's going on?" And so I think my inkling to do something started that day and like, yeah, let's give Trump a chance, but dot, dot, dot.

And so when I was at YC, they were very gracious and let me take some time off to just focus on how I can put my skills to help Trump get not reelected to elect Biden essentially. And part of that also, honestly, I don't know if I should really say this, but my parents voted for Trump, and my first thing I wanted to do because I didn't know if they

were going to vote for them or not, was to go to Wisconsin and just find a few voters and make sure they voted for Biden so that I could undo, cancel out their votes.

And so that's where I actually started was in Wisconsin, just I was talking to voters there and just trying to figure out what can I do to get people in a swing state? That's a swing state too.

Jessica: Wait, your parents were living in Wisconsin?

Adora: Yes.

Jessica: Oh, okay. So you were really going local here with this solution.

Adora: Yeah, I put up Craigslist postings. I was just trying to meet people. I was taking people to coffee like, "Hey, I want to understand who'd you voted for last time and where do you thinking now?" And just trying to do that. Talking to users I guess is what I was attempting to do. And I did that for a little bit, but it was clearly not going to scale. That's what the candidates are doing. They meet a lot of people and they convince them, try to vote for them and that's not my purpose. And I started looking more on... This is during COVID of course.

Carolynn: Oh my gosh.

Adora: And so someone pointed to vote by mail as something to look into and I forgot who it was. And so vote by mail, obviously a lot of people had to register to do that, and therefore get the ballots in the mail and then obviously send it in. And I just realized at that point I was like, "Oh, a lot of these states are allowing this to happen now." And this is probably the way... A lot of people don't go vote because they don't want to stand in line and deal with that.

But now that you don't have to go stand in line, this is the way to get people to vote and you can get people who otherwise wouldn't have more so than you would if they had to go vote in person. And so I just started looking deeply into that. And then what I discovered was when you sign up to vote by mail, first of all, the sites that you go to do it are clunky. It's very hard to do.

Jessica: Surprise, surprise.

Adora: And it's just a little bit hard to do. In some states it's like I remember in Florida they're always trying to check the voter registration base to let you sign up to vote by mail. In Florida, they had some bugs in their form. And for example, if you had like an accent on your name and you didn't put a name, you just put E instead of X and E like you wouldn't go through and so it just said you weren't registered and stuff like that.

Jessica: Oh my god.

Adora: In Florida there's a lot of people with accent names of course. Anyways, that part of it is just that realization, "Okay, people probably need help, what's the actual website", and stuff like that. And the other piece then was, okay, how do I get people to the site to finally register for it? Once you have that information, they registered to vote by mail, then you can contact them and make sure they got the ballots and stuff like that.

Oh, I should say the other unique piece about this is the vote by mail you could get a lot from the election offices in terms of data on if people registered to vote by mail when the ballot got actually sent to them. And if the ballot got returned. You didn't know who you voted for, but you could see the ballots.

Jessica: Wow.

Adora: So you can see they're low in terms of the conversion funnel, you can back out where they are in that funnel if you have their information. And so then it became going back a little bit further, okay, how do we get people to submit that information to us so that we can track them and make sure that they voted or continue badger them until they voted. And that was through ads essentially because that's how you reach a lot of people at scale obviously is through ads.

And so I looked at it and I was like, "Okay, someone must have figured this out. This is a very obvious thing at this point that there should be someone running a lot of ads and optimizing the conversion funnel to get voter information, making sure that they successfully sign up to vote by mail in that at the right times they get to the next steps of submitting the ballot and the ballot actually gets returned."

I started running ads myself at some point, but I was just sort of like, someone must've been doing this already. This seems like the most obvious thing to do. It's such a typical e-commerce type of thinking. But then I started searching around for this and no one was really doing it. There was an organization in which we started a pack together called Tech for Campaigns that had been running some similar experiments.

And so I basically went to them and we decided to start this for the general election because they had run some experience and so they had some knowledge already, and they were the only ones who were even thinking about it this way. At least from end-to-end funnel. There are a lot of organizations out there who will just do the ads, meaning they'll just put out the ads and then their success is whether someone clicked on the ads, but they don't get it so that they actually submit the ballot, that they actually vote.

And so it's just putting all these pieces together. As far as I know no one was doing it. And so I started the team, I recruited one of my former batch mates, Mark Lindsay, to help me run this. And he ran most of the tech part of this. And so he brought on engineers to start this up. We brought in some marketing folks and I was the one mostly working on the ads with the designer and just analyzing the entire funnel and doing the optimizations.

And obviously to do this so we put it together, we were able to go through the Florida primaries. That was the last primary in which we were able to test this. Had really great results. We were able to show that our ads resulted in more people voting than they otherwise wouldn't have.

And then we took those learnings and decided we're just going to go all out onto the general election. And so we picked five swing states to run this in: Wisconsin, Pennsylvania, Minnesota, Michigan, and Florida, and raised money for these states. And obviously the biggest funder of that was Jessica herself. Thank you very much.

Jessica: Paul and me.

Adora: Paul and Jessica. They were the biggest funder of the whole entire campaign. And yeah, we got the votes in. I mean who knows how much we actually influenced everything, but in the swing states we got a lot of votes in.

Carolynn: I have a really quick question because in theory what Adora is describing here, it's nonpartisan because in theory the entire electorate benefits from having optionality when it comes to how they vote for a million different reasons. So this isn't obviously Democrat versus Republican.

Adora: Yes.

Carolynn: Yeah, it's okay.

Jessica: I was just going to point out the same point. I was just going to say this wasn't impacting which way people were voting. It was merely getting people who wouldn't have otherwise voted to vote.

Carolynn: It's accessibility.

Adora: Yeah, I mean obviously we targeted certain people for this and honestly the ads that worked well were the most nonpartisan ads ever. It was just like a reminder, you've got two days to sign up to do this. Reminder: you got one more day, and just those are the ones that drove the most signups in.

Jessica: But your efforts had a big impact in certain swing states I remember.

Adora: Yeah, I think so. We were able to track and follow around 270,000 voters to submit an actual vote. And where we likely made a huge contribution was in two states, one Pennsylvania where we got around 50,000 votes in and the margin of win there was just 80,000 votes. In Wisconsin where we got 40,000 votes in and the margin of win there was around 20,000 votes. So of course we can't be sure how many votes we were 100% responsible for, but we did make a deliberate effort to avoid cannibalizing other initiatives by finding people who weren't likely to vote otherwise.

Jessica: What do you think the biggest takeaways are from this?



Adora: So overall, the key high level takeaways I've gotten from this whole entire process are one, this is complex, but it doesn't have to be a hard and costly problem. When you have the right mindset and the right data set, you don't need that much innovation or money to efficiently get the votes in. People do want to vote at some level, so like Carolynn mentioned before, your job is to just make it as easy as possible to get them from start to finish.

And I just think big donors should not give money to organizations who can't show they're metrics driven in being efficient with their dollars. I think too much today goes to waste. The second I touched on a little bit before, which is government forms in particular, their photo registration and vote by mail forms need to massively improve.

Jessica: As far as I'm concerned, you're like my hero for doing that Adora, and you did this all literally behind the scenes. Even the Democratic Party did not know you were doing this.

Adora: I try to explain it also to people to this day, and I think they're just like, "Really? That was it. That worked?" And I was just like, "Yeah, nobody is doing this. Nobody's just optimizing that entire funnel." It's too separate. People are just in charge of different things and no one just comes together and puts the whole funnel together. And that's an important piece.

And one of the things, there was an organization that had more money than us to do vote by mail. We were probably the second biggest organization in terms of money to do this. And they were just running ads, like meme type ads, meme ads, and I was just like, "Is that really working?" So we tested this, we took their ads, put it in our funnel, and yes, the click-through rate on that ad was extremely high.

Funny people are going to want to click on it, but the follow through and actually getting to a sign-up to getting them registered to vote was 0%. And so there was this money just being wasted doing these things because they're not tracking the whole entire thing anyway.

Jessica: Such a waste of money. They need more people like you. The DNC needs more Adora chunks and Mark Lindsay's and your whole team. This is my own personal opinion, but I feel-

Carolynn: I agree.

Jessica: ... I want to shift to your new thing. Instalab, I want you to tell me everything because Carolynn, do you know much about it?

Carolynn: I do not. So I'm glad we're going to dive in.

Jessica: Let's dive in.

Adora: So Instalab, I'll tell briefly about why I'm doing it. So Instalab, we're an at-home blood testing service that teaches, coaches people on how to optimize their health and how to

reach peak health. And our target audience is busy people, so founders, executives, working parents. And the reason why we're targeting that, it comes from my own place of my health going backwards essentially.

But busy people in general, well founders because I know, they know that they're making their startup the top priority and they know that they should be focusing on their health, but they don't have time for that. And so it's trying to get people in a place of, first you got to understand where you're at in terms of where's your health at and then what are the time efficient things you can do to make sure you're going in the right direction and not the wrong direction.

If you go to a doctor, they might tell you, you got to change your diet drastically and you got to do all these things. You got to exercise three or four hours a week and stuff like that. And we're just taking the approach of we want to understand where you're currently at and then what are the baby steps to get you in the right direction.

And so I started this company because after Homejoy, I had a bunch of health issues that I have to reverse. I had gained a lot of weight. My lipids, my cholesterol was really high, hypertension, metabolic issues, stuff like that, just a whole of thing.

Jessica: Were you eating junk food, processed food from McDonald's?

Carolynn: McDonald's.

Adora: Yeah, I mean to this day the employees at our company will make fun of me when I meet up with them for social hour or whatever. Yeah, my diet was auto-convenience. It wasn't for taste or substance or anything. It was just neat energy to move on to get through the day. And it was a lot of caffeine. Drinking Red Bull. I drink four or five Red Bull a day. It was anyway, too much caffeine.

Carolynn: Let me take a sip of coffee and think about that.

Adora: I started reading a lot about health and reading a lot of research and tests you can take to see where you're at, your genetics and stuff like that. And just had this realization after talking to multiple physicians, just like I had accumulated a lot of life debt, I guess is what you'd call it. So in engineering we have this term called tech debt, which is basically you keep piling on code and you don't really fix things. And as you keep piling in the code, it just becomes harder and harder to fix it in the future.

And this is what I mean by life debt is if you accumulate all these health problems when you're younger, there's all these diseases associated with old age like heart attacks, dementia, things like that. That's how you rapidly get into the mode of getting to that kind of category. And so I just started looking and I was like, "You know what? I could have totally fixed this or if I'd just known the issue existed and then just knew how to fit that into my lifestyle or how I could have just done X I could have been doing Y." Things like that.

And so part of the whole concept is, like I said, it's hard around busy people and so we try to not make you think too much about it or we are like, you don't need to go to the doctor's office, you don't need to go sit at a lab, do this. We're going to come right into your home. It takes 15 minutes. Someone's going to draw your blood, they're going to take your measurements, blood pressure, weight, even grip strength, stuff like that

Jessica: In your home.

Adora: In your home.

Jessica: They're going to come.

Adora: Or your office. We go to offices too all the time. It takes, like I said, 15 minutes out of your day and sometimes less. And then we send you the results and we try to just explain everything to you where you're at. And so it's obviously up to you on the next steps you take, but here are the three or four things you should do now and then just go from there.

Jessica: So what would these results... I presume you did them on yourself, what did they tell you about your health? You need to lose a certain amount of weight. What did it tell you?

Adora: So I had the typical issues I think a lot of founders have when they're not taking it themselves. So you have high lipids, high cholesterol LDL, high APOE, hypertension, just high blood pressure and a lot of inflammation.

Jessica: Wow.

Adora: And so you can detect this. So our panel is of 60 biomarkers, and so these are the things you can detect. And I'd say for our patients that they're usually from mid-20s to the 50s, and those are the things, metabolic issue, cardiovascular issue, and high blood pressure are the top three things that people have problems with.

And you don't know. You don't know you have these problems, they're like these silent killers. You just figure it out when you have a heart attack or one of these cardiovascular bad events. And so I had these issues and I got to the point where everything was red, red, red, red, red. And it just took me, you never want to get to that point when you're blood pressure-

Jessica: And you were like 30?

Adora: Yeah. I'm in my early 30s when I'm discovering this. And it took me a long time just to get it all back down. And you never want to get to that point. You maybe things are in the yellow and that's when you want to start fixing that because it's so much easier. You don't have to focus on it as much and just little things you have to do here and there.

Jessica: Wow.

Adora: I posted a blog post the other day, I don't know why, but I just never thought to put out the reason why I started this company. And so I finally did that and then I got a lot of good feedback. People are like, "Oh, thank you for seeing this." A lot of people on their second startup in particular were like, "Oh my God, that's exactly where I was. I just screwed my health up and I shouldn't have done that." And I think the thing I'm trying to tell people is that you can still make your company top priority and still be healthy. It's totally in the realm of possibility.

Jessica: It's just having the knowledge. It's just not being a denial. I mean, knowing founders the way I do, they're hyper focused on their company. They don't have time to worry about their health and they eat badly and they are stressed. And I think if it were easily pointed out to them, hold on, you're going down a bad path, they might do something about it.

Carolynn: Well, I just think it's overwhelming, like health as a category seems overwhelming and expensive and time consuming. And so it's so easy to push it off. So if your company's like, we'll just break it down into bite-sized pieces and make it easy for you to change course, I can imagine that's incredibly appealing to your demographic.

Adora: Yeah, I think a blood panel can't tell you everything obviously, but it can tell you a lot. And for most people it's finding a hidden health risk that they have. I would say well over 95, I don't know, close to 100% of our patients are finding something that they didn't know they have an issue with.

Jessica: Really? Close to 100%?

Adora: Close to 100%, yeah.

Jessica: Wow.

Carolynn: Are you doing this just in New York right now?

Adora: We are in New York, we're in San Francisco, we are in LA and Austin.

Jessica: Okay. I think the Levys need to sign up.

Carolynn: We'll totally try. I had no idea it was local. I just assumed you guys were still just on the East coast.

Adora: No, no, no, we were in... Yeah, now, we're where all the founders are.

Jessica: So what happens after you get the results, then what's next for Instalab? Like what follow on stuff do they do?

Adora: There are a number of things. You can talk to a physician. We have a longevity physician that you can talk to, if you have more questions. So some people do that. The recommendations are pretty straightforward. And so what we tell people is, if you do any of these, you should let us know and then retest in about three months because

that's when you can start seeing a lot of these things actually moving in the right direction. And part of this is, and I think a lot of people like this, especially founders just because it's that feedback loop in the numbers.

Jessica: I was just going to say this must totally appeal to the founders.

Adora: Oh yeah, totally.

Jessica: Data.

Adora: And the way healthcare works right now is you go in the doctor's office, blah, blah, blah, they give you a super basic lipid panel and then you get the results two weeks later or something and maybe the doctor explains it to you and then maybe in the next two or three years you go do it again. And if the results come back really bad, the doctor's going to be like, you should go lose some weight or something generic like that.

And then you got to wait another year or two years to go see if that worked or not. You're like, no, you need to get that data immediately on whether you're doing the right thing or not. And also just getting that data it's more incentive to keep doing it because you know it's working versus having to wait around for a year to figure out if that works.

Carolynn: Is there any similarity in onboarding phlebotomists to your platform as employing cleaners onto the Homejoy platform? What are the similarities there?

Adora: So the main difference between that and this is we are hiring full-time employees or W-2, no more ten-nines done, I'm done with that. The problem with nine-nines is many. Some people like it, some of the contracts actually like it because it's flexible work and whatnot. But the problem from our end is that you can't control quality. You can't standardize, you can't tell them this is the way you do the job. And so it gets awry.

So we have hired full-time employees for this. And our price point is a bit higher. So we're able to take the taxes and everything, the workers' comp, things that come with hiring W-2 employers were set on that. And I am dead set on this. I'm doing it this way this time. That is the main difference. Similarities are you got to still interview them, you got to make sure folks... At Homejoy, the difference between a one-star and five-star review was frequently actually not whether the clean went well, whether it was actually clean or not was whether they showed up on time, like reliability. That's a big thing.

And so you got to interview for that. And so it's similar interview questions you're asking, but in terms of whether they can do the job or not, obviously I got like, here's my arm, prick me and I hope it doesn't hurt. And so have my arm pricked a lot because one of the things is we want to make it painless. As painless as possible because people are afraid of needles. What's so funny, when I made it a rule that I was not going to start a company that involved going into people's homes again and scaling up people in that manner, but here I'm-

Carolynn: Oops, you did it again.

Jessica: Oh, Adora.

Adora: I have not learned any lessons from that.

Carolynn: That's funny.

Jessica: Famous last words. I love the idea that you were saying baby steps because I think with health and weight loss and stuff, that's such a key. I mean, I should lose 30 pounds, but there's no way I'm going to set my sights on that. I just desperately cling to the hope that I can lose five pounds.

Adora: So here's the thing, like a lot of our patients are vitamin D deficient, which makes sense. We're all inside our computers and blah, blah, blah, blah. Yeah. So there are supplements you can take, but you should get some sunlight because not only will it increase your vitamin D but it's highly associated with being in a good mood and de-risks yourself from getting depression and stuff like that.

And so the baby step there is like, okay, look at your calendar. You've got at least one phone call or one meeting on your calendar that you can make a phone call. Convert that into just walking outside, taking that call when it's on outside. So that's what I mean by baby steps is just take your existing schedule, your existing lifestyle and just make tiny edits to it. So you start on the path of-

Carolynn: This sounds like Noom, right? It's similar, that's very, very just diet, I believe.

Jessica: Yes, I use Noom.

Carolynn: Okay. But so here's the thing, don't they just really break it down and just make it very easy to make incremental life's food changes. That's what that sounds like.

Jessica: Yeah. But I failed on Noom. I basically now just use it to track my weight. That just is plateaus, basically. But yes, they try to make it baby steps.

Adora: I don't know if you want to do this, Jessica. There's a startup by two former YC founders, Erin Eba and-

Jessica: Oh yeah.

Adora: ... David Yang, and it's called Supportive. And basically you hook up. I'm on this now with all of them. You hook up your scale to the app, and once you step on it just sends it out to everyone and people support you.

Jessica: I'm sitting here with my mouth open because I'm thinking about the horror of having everyone know my weight when I step.

Adora: But you get so much support.

Jessica: Oh wait, seriously, Adora, tell me what happens. You step on the scale, it goes out to a group of how many people?

Adora: Well, it's a group you want, so it's not everyone.

Jessica: Okay. Let's just say your group is 20 friends or whatever.

Adora: Yes. Yeah. And so it's people just carrying you on and then you can log what you did the previous day and stuff like that.

Jessica: Oh my God.

Adora: I use it and I have four or five people following me. It's like Erin, David and Anson Tsai. I don't know if you remember him.

Jessica: Of course, I remember Anson.

Adora: Yeah.

Jessica: Okay. But back to Instalab, I feel like every founder, this is a no-brainer. Every founder should be doing this.

Adora: Right, yes.

Jessica: What a fun time I had chatting and catching up with you. Adora, we loved having you on the show today. I loved hearing the old stories, but I'm also so excited to learn more about Instalab. It sounds fabulous.

Carolynn: It does.

Adora: Thank you. And thank you for having me.

Jessica: And hopefully we will see you soon.

Carolynn: Great to see you, Adora.

Adora: Bye.

Carolynn: Thank you.

Jessica: Okay. Bye.

Carolynn: Bye.

Adora: Bye.

Jessica: That was so much fun catching up with Adora, Carolynn.

Carolynn: I've been wanting to catch up with her for a long time, and it's funny that it ended up happening as on a podcast recorded, but she's just a person I really admire and love to talk to, and so I'm really glad she came on.

Jessica: I'm too. And like I said, I rarely ask people about their failure because I think most people are in denial about their failure and won't be totally honest about why they failed.

Carolynn: Yeah.

Jessica: That's the trap you fall into. They have their own sort of made up reasons.

Carolynn: Narrative. Yeah, yeah.

Jessica: Yeah. Their own narrative. But I feel like I trust Adora to have been honest with herself about what went wrong.

Carolynn: Well, and quite frankly, I think that's a job wreck for being a YC partner. You can't be in denial. You have to have extracted those lessons. And then one of the goals is to like, hey, let me tell you what, you may not know about this trajectory you're on or this thing you're deciding because been there, done that. So I think that's really important. And it doesn't surprise me at all.

And I'll say Adora, before she was a YC partner, I think, or maybe at the very beginning, she did a dinner talk, and it's one of my favorites because she was talking about her family a little bit and the whole star child thing. I'm still laughing about that. It's just so funny to me.

Jessica: I had forgotten that quote. "What have you done with my star child?"

Carolynn: No, totally just my star child. John and I occasionally, it's like a meme in the Levy household occasionally, and we'll bring it up because we were both chuckling about that for a long time. Anyway, yeah, it was great to talk to her.

Jessica: Yeah, I miss her at YC. I mean, I'm glad this new idea sounds really cool.

Carolynn: It does.

Jessica: So I'm glad she's working on that. And she's just so clearly someone who... She's a founder at heart. She wants to be building, making, changing, improving things in the world. So I'm happy she's doing Instalab, but I certainly do miss her at YC.

Carolynn: Yeah, I do too.

Jessica: And loved hearing her story. Loved that. So I think it'll be a good one. Can't wait for it to come out.

Carolynn: Same. All right, well I'll talk to you soon.



Jessica: All right, talk to you soon. See Levy.

Carolynn: Bye.

Jessica: Bye.